Terrain-Aware A* with Robot-Grounded Traversability Costs: A Reproducible Evaluation for Tracked UGVs on Uneven Terrain

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***Abstract*—Shortest-path planners routinely send ground robots across slopes and rough patches that a cost-aware planner would avoid at small extra distance. We study a simple and fully specified terrain-aware planner for tracked unmanned ground vehicles (UGVs): a traversability cost that is normalised by the robot's own limits (slope limit and roughness saturation), embedded in A* as a multiplicative edge cost with an admissible heuristic (TA*), followed by a shortcutting step that provably never increases the integrated cost (TA*-S). Our main contribution is a careful, reproducible evaluation: 120 test scenarios over four procedurally generated terrain families and three map scales, a held-out validation split used only to select the terrain weight, planner-independent safety and energy metrics, and paired non-parametric statistics. Against terrain-unaware A* and Theta*, TA*-S changes the median traversability cost along the path by -48.2% relative to A* and never enters terrain steeper than the slope limit, whereas A* and Theta* do so in 76% and 82% of the scenarios; the median path-length change is +6.6% and the median change in estimated energy is -5.0%. Compared with a binary-traversability baseline (hard slope constraint only), the continuous cost further lowers the slope, roughness and climb along the path (all $p < 0.001$, Holm-corrected). We also report the trade-off over the terrain weight, a cost ablation, robustness to elevation-map noise and computation time. Code and data generators are released.**

***Index Terms*—path planning, traversability, field robotics, unmanned ground vehicles, uneven terrain**

I. Introduction

Field robots in agriculture, construction and disaster response operate on terrain where the shortest path is often not the best one: a straight line over a hill or through a rough patch costs energy, increases the risk of slipping or tipping, and may exceed the vehicle's climbing capability. Terrain-aware planning addresses this by attaching a traversability cost to the map and searching for paths that trade distance against terrain difficulty [1], [2].

The idea itself is well established—planetary rovers have used traversability maps for two decades [3], [4]—and adding a terrain term to a graph-search cost is, algorithmically, a small step. What is often less clear in practice is *how much* such a cost actually buys on a given robot, under which conditions, and at what price in distance, energy and computation. Answering this requires evaluations whose metrics are tied to the robot (e.g., distance driven on slopes beyond its limit), whose baselines include both terrain-unaware and binary traversability planners, whose parameters are not tuned on the test data, and whose statistics respect the paired design of planner benchmarks.

This paper provides such an evaluation for a tracked UGV. Our contributions are:

1) A fully specified terrain-aware planner: a slope/roughness cost normalised by the robot's limits rather than by per-map maxima, combined with hard constraints, used as a multiplicative edge cost in A* with an admissible heuristic (TA*), and a cost-aware shortcutting step (TA*-S) that never increases the integrated cost (Sec. III).
2) A reproducible benchmark of 120 test and 60 validation scenarios over four terrain families and three scales, with a pre-specified rule for selecting the terrain weight on the validation split only (Sec. IV).
3) An evaluation with planner-independent safety and energy metrics and paired, multiplicity-corrected statistics, including the distance–terrain trade-off, an ablation of the cost terms, robustness to elevation noise and computation time (Sec. V).

All numbers in this paper are generated from the released raw results by a single script.

II. Related Work

Grid search. A* [5] finds minimum-cost paths on grids given an admissible heuristic; D* Lite [6] supports efficient replanning. Any-angle planners such as Theta* [7], [8] and Field D* [4] remove the grid's heading restriction; Field D* additionally interpolates costs across cells and was deployed on Mars rovers. Sampling-based planners such as RRT* [9] scale to higher-dimensional state spaces but are not the focus here.

Traversability. Surveys [1], [2] distinguish geometric approaches, which derive slope, roughness and step height from

elevation maps or point clouds, from appearance- and learning-based ones. Elevation mapping with uncertainty [10] and SLAM systems such as RTAB-Map [11] provide the maps on which such features are computed. Geometric traversability costs have been used for legged robots [12], for planning directly on point clouds [13] and for energy-efficient paths on uneven terrain [14].

Positioning. We do not propose a new search algorithm. We contribute a carefully specified cost and planner for tracked UGVs and, mainly, an evaluation protocol whose metrics, baselines, data split and statistics make the benefit of terrain awareness measurable and reproducible.

III. Method

A. Elevation map and terrain features

The environment is a 2.5D elevation map $z(x, y)$ on a grid of resolution $\Delta = 0.5\,\mathrm{m}$, as produced, for example, from an RTAB-Map point cloud [11]. For each cell we compute the slope $\theta = \arctan \|\nabla z\|$ (central differences) and the roughness ρ, the local standard deviation (3×3 window) of the residual $z - G_\sigma * z$ after removing smooth relief with a Gaussian filter ($\sigma = 1.5$ cells). Geometric obstacles (rocks) are inflated by the robot's footprint radius r_f.

B. Robot-grounded cost and constraints

Let $\theta_{\max}$ be the robot's admissible slope and ρ_{sat} a roughness at which the roughness penalty saturates. The cost of a cell is

$$c = \alpha \min\Big(\frac{\theta}{\theta_{\max}}, 1\Big) + \beta \min\Big(\frac{\rho}{\rho_{\mathrm{sat}}}, 1\Big), \quad \alpha + \beta = 1, \quad (1)$$

so $c \in [0, 1]$. Because the normalisers are robot properties, the same terrain receives the same cost on every map; normalising by the per-map maximum, as is sometimes done, makes costs incomparable across maps and lets a single outlier rescale the whole map. Cells with $\theta > \theta_{\max}$ or inside an inflated obstacle are *lethal*. We use $\theta_{\max} = 25^\circ$, $\rho_{\mathrm{sat}} = 0.10\,\mathrm{m}$, $r_f = 0.5\,\mathrm{m}$ and $(\alpha, \beta) = (0.7, 0.3)$; these values were fixed before any experiment and are ablated in Sec. V-D.

C. Terrain-Aware A* (TA*)

The grid is 8-connected without corner cutting. The cost of moving between neighbouring free cells u, v at horizontal distance d_{uv} is

$$k(u, v) = d_{uv}\Big(1 + w\,\frac{c_u + c_v}{2}\Big), \quad (2)$$

with terrain weight $w \geq 0$. The path cost g accumulates k; the heuristic is the Euclidean distance to the goal.

Proposition 1. *For any $w \geq 0$ the Euclidean heuristic is consistent for* (2)*; hence TA* returns a minimum-cost path.*

Proof. Since $c \geq 0$, $k(u, v) \geq d_{uv} \geq h(u) - h(v)$ by the triangle inequality. Consistency implies optimality of A* [5]. □

Note that the terrain term must enter the *accumulated* cost g: adding it only to the priority $f = g + h + w\,c(n)$ changes the expansion order but not the objective that the returned path optimises. With $w = 0$, TA* reduces to A* with hard constraints (A*-HC), i.e., binary traversability.

D. Cost-aware shortcutting (TA*-S)

Grid paths contain heading artefacts. Standard string-pulling removes them but can cut straight across costly terrain. TA*-S shortcuts greedily: from waypoint p_i it extends a straight segment to the farthest p_j such that (i) the segment is collision-free with respect to lethal cells (a conservative visibility test that also checks cells touched at boundaries) and (ii) its integrated cost $\int (1 + w\,c)\,ds$ does not exceed the cost of the original sub-path $p_i \ldots p_j$ evaluated with the same quadrature.

Proposition 2. *TA*-S never increases the integrated path cost and never enters a lethal cell.*

Proof. Each accepted shortcut replaces a sub-path by a segment of no greater cost that passes the visibility test; the result is a concatenation of such segments. □

IV. Experimental Setup

A. Terrains and scenarios

We generate four terrain families (Fig. 1): *hills* (fractal relief, median slope 11°), *ridge* (gentle relief with a steep ridge across the start–goal line and one or two passes), *craters* (gentle relief with 6–11 crater-like depressions) and *rocky* (gentle relief, rough patches and scattered rocks). Relief is produced by $1/f^\beta$ spectral synthesis and scaled to a target median slope, so slope statistics are comparable across the three map sizes (50, 100 and 200 m, i.e., up to 400×400 cells). A centimetre-scale micro relief is added everywhere. The start lies in the left and the goal in the right band of the map. A scenario is kept only if a path exists under the hard constraints, so every planner faces a solvable instance; 1 of the 120 test scenarios needed a redraw. Each (family, size) cell contains 10 test seeds; a disjoint set of seeds (60 scenarios) forms the validation split. All randomness is seeded and independent of the Python hash seed.

B. Planners

A* (shortest path, obstacles only), Theta* (Lazy Theta* [8], any-angle shortest path, obstacles only), A*-HC (shortest path with hard constraints), TA* and TA*-S. All planners share the same grid, neighbourhood, data structures and language (Python 3, single thread), so their computation times are comparable to each other but not to optimised C++ implementations.

C. Terrain-weight selection

The terrain weight is selected on the validation split with a rule fixed in advance: the largest $w \in \{0, 0.5, 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32\}$ whose median path-length overhead of TA*-S relative to $w = 0$ is at most 10%. This gives $w = 16$ (median overhead 8.7% on validation). The test split is never used for tuning; the full sweep on the test split is reported for transparency (Sec. V-C).

D. Metrics

All paths are resampled every 0.1 m and evaluated on the ground-truth map with the same code: horizontal length; cumulative climb (sum of positive elevation changes); maximum and 95th-percentile slope under the path; *steep length*, the distance driven on cells with $\theta > \theta_{\max}$; mean cost $\bar{c}$ (1); 95th-percentile roughness; and an energy estimate $E = mg(\mu_r L + H^+)$ with $m = 150$ kg, rolling-resistance coefficient $\mu_r = 0.15$, length L and climb H^+ (no regeneration). The energy model is deliberately simple and is used only for relative comparisons.

E. Statistics

Planners are compared on the same scenarios, so we use paired two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank tests [15], report the median paired difference and the matched-pairs rank-biserial correlation r [16] as effect size, and correct all 24 tests with Holm's method [17]. Distributions are summarised by median and interquartile range (IQR) because computation times and several metrics are strongly skewed.

V. Results

A. Main comparison

Table I summarises the 120 test scenarios and Table II the paired tests. All planners solve every scenario. The terrain-unaware planners A* and Theta* enter terrain steeper than $\theta_{\max}$ in 76% and 82% of the scenarios, driving on average 8.5 m and 8.1 m on such slopes. A*-HC avoids lethal cells by construction but hugs the limit: its median maximum slope is 23.7° against $\theta_{\max} = 25°$. TA*-S keeps a margin: the median maximum slope under the path is 12.9° and the median maximum pitch over 1 m windows is 11.4° (A*: 26.8°, A*-HC: 19.0°).

Relative to A* on the same scenario, TA*-S changes the mean traversability cost by -48.2%, the cumulative climb by -40.2% and the estimated energy by -5.0% (median), at a median path-length increase of 6.6%. Against A*-HC, the continuous cost changes the 95th-percentile slope by -9.27° and the climb by -0.95 m (median paired differences, $|r| \geq 0.98$). Against Theta*, which produces the shortest paths, TA*-S is longer by a median of +9.95 m while the energy estimate does not differ significantly ($p = 0.973$): the extra distance is paid for by less climbing. The shortcutting step matters: compared with plain TA*, TA*-S changes the length by -4.41 m (median) and uses less energy in every scenario ($r = -1.00$), at a small cost increase of +0.010.

B. Terrain families

Table III breaks the results down by terrain family. Exposure of the terrain-unaware planners is highest on the ridge terrain (97% of A* paths), where the shortest path crosses the ridge flank instead of using a pass. The energy benefit of TA*-S is largest on craters (-14.7%) and smallest on hills (-0.7%), where elevation changes cannot be avoided by short detours. On rocky terrain the roughness term dominates: the 95th-percentile roughness under the path is 43 mm for TA*-S versus 113 mm for A* and 104 mm for A*-HC.

C. Terrain-weight trade-off

Fig. 2 shows the full sweep on the test split. Increasing w moves along a smooth distance–cost front with diminishing returns: the median cost of TA*-S falls from 0.295 ($w = 0$) to 0.198 ($w = 2$) and 0.150 ($w = 16$), while the length change relative to A* grows from -3.1% to -0.9% and 6.6%. Shortcutting shifts the whole front towards shorter paths. The energy estimate is minimised at intermediate weights (-9.6% at $w = 2$), because large weights add distance to avoid moderate slopes that cost little energy. The weight therefore encodes a mission preference: our validation rule, which bounds the length overhead, selects a safety-oriented $w = 16$; a mission that prioritises energy would choose $w \approx 2$, which is still free of steep exposure by virtue of the hard constraint.

D. Cost ablation

Table IV varies the slope weight α ($\beta = 1 - \alpha$). A roughness-only cost ($\alpha = 0$) leaves the 95th-percentile slope at 13.5°; any slope weight $\alpha \geq 0.25$ lowers it to 8.8° or less. Conversely, the 95th-percentile roughness grows from 17.9 mm to 22.3 mm as the roughness term is removed. The two terms thus act on the quantities they are designed for, and the default $\alpha = 0.7$ lies on the flat part of the slope curve while retaining most of the roughness avoidance.

E. Robustness to elevation noise

Real elevation maps are noisy. We add i.i.d. Gaussian noise $\sigma_z \in \{0.02, 0.05, 0.10\}$ m to the elevation used for planning and evaluate the resulting paths on the ground truth (Fig. 3). Noise inflates the estimated slope, so both planners occasionally misjudge cells near the limit and enter truly steep terrain. Because TA* keeps a margin from $\theta_{\max}$, its exposure stays smaller than that of A*-HC (mean 0.03 m vs. 0.10 m at $\sigma_z = 0.10$ m); both remain at or above 99.2% success. The mean cost of TA* paths rises from 0.154 to 0.205, i.e., the benefit degrades gracefully. Filtering the map before computing slopes, or using an uncertainty-aware elevation map [10], is the natural remedy.

F. Computation time

Terrain awareness has a price in search effort: with $w > 0$ the Euclidean heuristic underestimates the true cost more, so TA* expands more nodes than A*. In our single-threaded Python implementation the median time on 100 m maps (200×200 cells) is 0.180 s for TA* and 0.294 s for TA*-S, against 0.038 s for A*; on 200 m maps it is 0.823 s and 1.295 s (Fig. 4); the maximum over all scenarios is 2.17 s. All planners scale similarly with map size. A compiled implementation, a multi-resolution map or incremental replanning with D* Lite [6] would reduce these times by large factors.

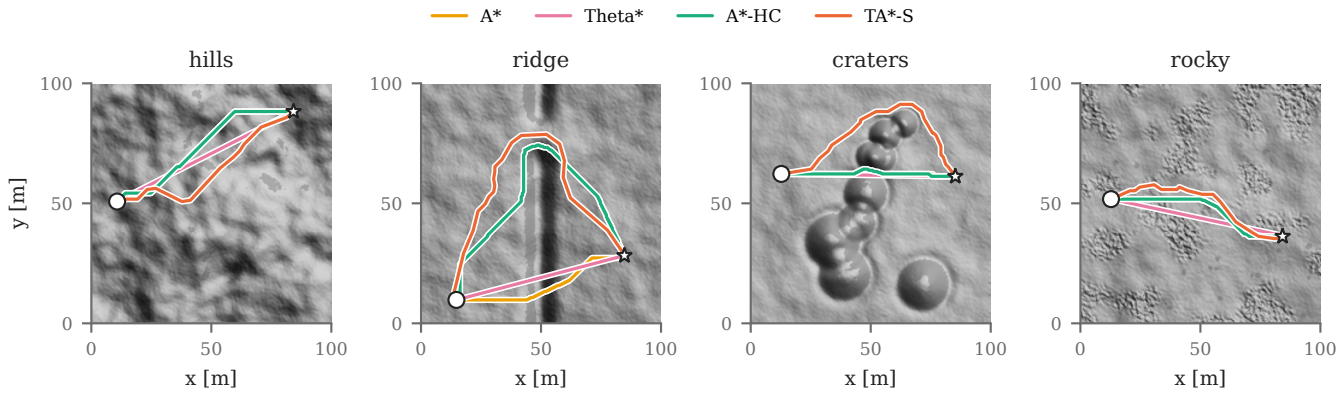


Fig. 1. Example test scenarios (100 m, seed 0) for the four terrain families on a hillshade; darker shading marks lethal cells (slope $> \theta_{\max}$ or inflated rocks). Circle: start, star: goal. Where lines are not visible they coincide with another planner's path (e.g., A* and A*-HC when no lethal cell lies on the shortest path).

TABLE I

RESULTS ON THE 120 TEST SCENARIOS. LENGTH AND ENERGY ARE RELATIVE TO A* ON THE SAME SCENARIO, MEDIAN [IQR]. MAX. SLOPE AND COST: MEDIANS. EXPOSED: SHARE OF PATHS THAT ENTER TERRAIN STEEPER THAN $\theta_{\max}$; STEEP LENGTH: MEAN LENGTH DRIVEN ON SUCH TERRAIN.

Planner	Succ. [%]	ΔLength [%]	ΔEnergy [%]	Max. slope [°]	Exposed [%]	Steep len. [m]	Cost $\bar{c}$	Time [s]
A*	100	0.0 [0.0, 0.0]	0.0 [0.0, 0.0]	31.1	76	8.5	0.324	0.037
Theta*	100	-5.7 [-7.0, -3.8]	-4.6 [-8.4, -1.5]	33.2	82	8.1	0.337	0.057
A*-HC	100	0.1 [0.0, 2.6]	-1.4 [-7.3, 0.0]	23.7	0	0.0	0.301	0.035
TA*	100	11.8 [7.7, 17.8]	-0.7 [-7.0, 3.6]	12.4	0	0.0	0.141	0.180
TA*-S	100	6.6 [2.6, 12.4]	-5.0 [-10.4, -0.4]	12.9	0	0.0	0.150	0.294

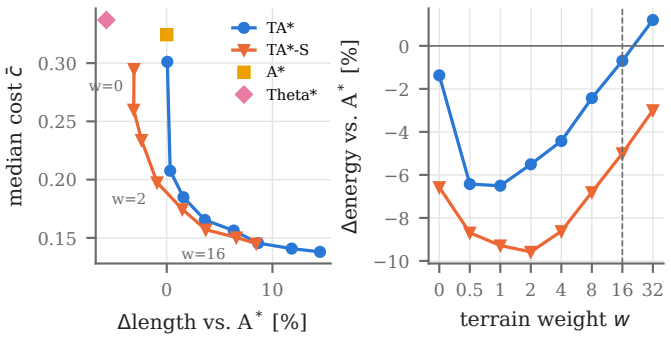


Fig. 2. Terrain-weight sweep on the test split (medians). Left: distance–cost trade-off of TA* and TA*-S, with A* and Theta* for reference. Right: estimated energy relative to A*; the dashed line marks the weight $w = 16$ selected on the validation split.

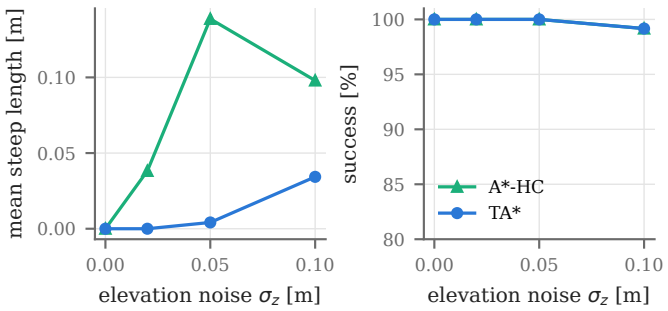


Fig. 3. Planning on a noisy elevation map, evaluation on the ground truth. Left: mean distance driven on slopes $> \theta_{\max}$. Right: success rate.

VI. DISCUSSION AND LIMITATIONS

Synthetic terrain. The terrains are procedural. They are designed to cover qualitatively different situations (unavoidable relief, a barrier with passes, local depressions, rough patches) and are scaled by slope, but they are not measured terrain. The pipeline accepts any elevation map; applying it to maps built with RTAB-Map [11] on our tracked UGV is the next step.

Isotropic cost. The cost depends on the slope magnitude, not on the heading. Driving along a contour on a side slope produces roll rather than pitch, which may be the more critical mode for some vehicles. A heading-dependent cost on a state lattice would capture this at higher search cost.

Energy and dynamics. The energy estimate ignores speed, slip, turning losses and regeneration, and no path is executed by a controller. The reported energy changes should therefore be read as relative indications, not predictions.

Implementation. Times are from a pure-Python implementation and are meant for comparison between planners, not as absolute real-time claims.

VII. CONCLUSION

A traversability cost normalised by the robot's own limits, embedded in A* with an admissible heuristic and followed by cost-aware shortcutting, removes all excursions onto slopes beyond the robot's limit that shortest-path planners make in most of our scenarios, roughly halves the mean traversability cost and lowers climb and estimated energy, at a median

TABLE II

PAIRED TWO-SIDED WILCOXON SIGNED-RANK TESTS OVER THE TEST SCENARIOS (N=120). $\tilde{d}$: MEDIAN PAIRED DIFFERENCE (FIRST MINUS SECOND); r: MATCHED-PAIRS RANK-BISERIAL CORRELATION; p: HOLM-CORRECTED OVER ALL 24 TESTS.

Comparison	Metric	$\tilde{d}$	r	p
TA*-S vs A*	cost $\bar{c}$	-0.152	-1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. slope [°]	-12.30	-1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. rough. [mm]	-7.1	-0.99	<0.001
	climb [m]	-1.69	-0.99	<0.001
	energy [kJ]	-1.24	-0.67	<0.001
	length [m]	+5.38	+0.93	<0.001
TA*-S vs Theta*	cost $\bar{c}$	-0.155	-1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. slope [°]	-11.97	-1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. rough. [mm]	-5.7	-0.99	<0.001
	climb [m]	-1.66	-0.95	<0.001
	energy [kJ]	+0.22	-0.00	0.973
	length [m]	+9.95	+1.00	<0.001
TA*-S vs A*-HC	cost $\bar{c}$	-0.125	-1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. slope [°]	-9.27	-1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. rough. [mm]	-4.5	-0.98	<0.001
	climb [m]	-0.95	-0.98	<0.001
	energy [kJ]	-0.55	-0.46	<0.001
	length [m]	+4.31	+0.90	<0.001
TA*-S vs TA*	cost $\bar{c}$	+0.010	+1.00	<0.001
	95th-pct. slope [°]	+0.42	+0.98	<0.001
	95th-pct. rough. [mm]	+0.4	+0.58	<0.001
	climb [m]	-0.06	-0.85	<0.001
	energy [kJ]	-1.06	-1.00	<0.001
	length [m]	-4.41	-1.00	<0.001

TABLE III

PER TERRAIN FAMILY (MEDIANS). $\bar{c}$: MEAN TRAVERSABILITY COST ALONG THE PATH; EXPOSED: SHARE OF PATHS ENTERING SLOPES $> \theta_{\max}$; Δ: TA*-S RELATIVE TO A*.

	$\bar{c}$				Exposed [%]		TA*-S Δ [%]	
Terrain	A*	Th*	HC	TA*-S	A*	Th*	Len.	Energy
hills	0.379	0.391	0.373	0.245	63	77	6.3	-0.7
ridge	0.284	0.281	0.251	0.141	97	90	9.6	-6.7
craters	0.373	0.356	0.279	0.131	83	80	7.2	-14.7
rocky	0.319	0.337	0.311	0.162	60	80	5.0	-4.2

distance overhead of a few percent. The terrain weight sets a clear distance–cost–energy trade-off that should be chosen per mission. We release the generator, planners, raw results and the analysis script that produces every number in this paper.

CODE AND DATA AVAILABILITY

All code, raw results and the analysis script are available at https://github.com/tako-1012/thesis_Bunker (directory `conference/`).

TABLE IV

ABLATION OF THE SLOPE/ROUGHNESS WEIGHTING ($\beta = 1 - \alpha$) FOR TA* ($w = 16$), MEDIANS OVER THE TEST SCENARIOS, EVALUATED WITH THE DEFAULT COST MAP.

α	slope$_{95}$ [°]	rough.$_{95}$ [mm]	climb [m]	length [m]
0.00	13.5	17.9	3.59	93.6
0.25	8.8	19.4	3.37	92.6
0.50	8.6	20.3	3.27	93.9
0.75	8.1	21.3	3.08	95.3
1.00	7.9	22.3	3.08	98.1

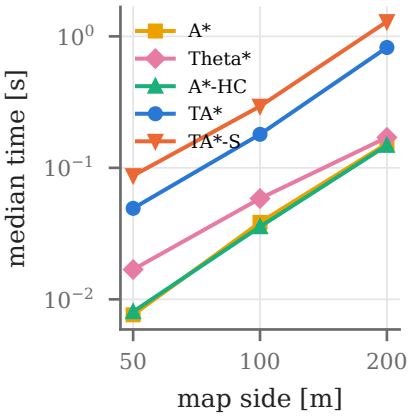


Fig. 4. Median planning time versus map side length (log–log). All planners share one Python implementation.

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